

1943 After victory in North Africa the Allies take Sicily and then invade mainland Italy, beginning a long campaign; Rome will not fall until June 1944. The US Army Air Forces continue their strategic bombing campaign against Germany.

1944 D-Day: US and Allied troops take part in the largest-ever amphibious landings on the beaches of Normandy in France as they begin the liberation of Europe from Nazi rule.

1944 In the Pacific, US forces continue to move closer to Japan, capturing islands in an air-land-sea campaign to bring the Japanese homeland within range of the US Army Air Forces' new B-29 bombers. In October US troops land in the Philippines.

1944 Roosevelt wins an unprecedented fourth term as president; Harry S. Truman is elected vice president.

1945 At Yalta in the Crimea, Roosevelt, Stalin, and Churchill meet for the last time to plan for the post-war world.

1945 US and Allied forces make a final push into Germany following the failure of a major German winter offensive in Belgium (the "Battle of the Bulge"). American units seize an intact bridge across the Rhine River in March, allowing the encirclement of the Ruhr region.

1945 Following the unexpected death of Roosevelt in April, Harry S. Truman becomes president. Within a month, the defeat of Nazi Germany brings the war in Europe to an end. At Potsdam, Germany, in late July, the Allied leaders demand the unconditional surrender of Japan.

1945 President Truman makes the decision to drop two atomic bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, bringing the war in Asia to an end in September. US troops under General Douglas MacArthur occupy Japan and begin to demobilize Japanese troops and reconstruct the country along democratic principles.

1945 The United Nations charter is signed by 51 nations in San Francisco. The US is one of the first signatories, supporting the UN as it had failed to support the League of Nations after World War I. The first UN meeting is in London, but it agrees to seek a permanent home in New York, where it meets for the first time on October 23, 1946.

1947 The Marshall Plan provides aid to stricken and devastated Europe.

1947 The House Un-American Activities Committee begins an investigation into supposed communist infiltration of the movie industry.

1948 The US armed forces are integrated for the first time.

1948 Harry S. Truman wins a surprise election victory over his Republican rival, Thomas Dewey.

1949 US joins the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), a mutual defense alliance of western democratic nations, the first time the US has entered into such an alliance in peacetime.

1950 Senator Joseph McCarthy leads an anticommunist witchhunt. He overreaches himself when, in 1954, he attacks the president, and is condemned by the Senate for misconduct.

“Ask not what your country can do for **you—ask what you can do for **your country**.”**

JOHN F. KENNEDY, INAUGURAL ADDRESS, WASHINGTON, DC, JANUARY 20, 1961

1950–53 Korean War: US and allies fight under the UN to prevent a communist takeover of Korea.

1952 Dwight D. Eisenhower, the Republican former Supreme Allied Commander in Western Europe during World War II, is elected president; Richard Nixon is vice president.

1954 Supreme Court rules racial segregation in schools is unconstitutional. African-Americans, seeking rights, begin a campaign of civil disobedience.

1955 Rock 'n' roll hits America as Bill Haley tops the charts with "Rock Around the Clock." The next year, Elvis Presley tops the charts for the first time.

1955–56 Boycott of racially segregated buses led by Martin Luther King succeeds in Montgomery, Alabama.

1957 US troops enforce desegregation of schools in Little Rock, Arkansas.

1959 Alaska and Hawaii become the 49th and 50th states of the Union. No new states have been admitted since.

1960 John F. Kennedy wins election as president by a narrow majority against his Republican opponent, Richard Nixon. A US-backed invasion of Cuba to overthrow Fidel Castro fails.

1961 The US manned space program begins when Commander Alan Shepard is launched into space. President Kennedy pledges to land a man on the moon by the end of the decade.

1962 Soviet missile bases are sited on Cuba; the threat of nuclear war is averted when the USSR decides not to launch the missiles.

1963 Martin Luther King, Jr. leads a massive civil rights demonstration in Washington, during which he makes his famous "I have a dream" speech.

1963 Kennedy is assassinated in Dallas, Texas; Lyndon B. Johnson, Kennedy's vice president, becomes president.

1964 Civil Rights Act outlaws racial discrimination in jobs and services.

1964 US involvement in Vietnam steps up after an incident in the Gulf of Tonkin, where the Vietnamese supposedly attack two American destroyers.

1964 Lyndon B. Johnson wins huge election victory over Republican Barry Goldwater.

1966 As America commits more troops to Vietnam, protests against the war build up and race riots break out in many US cities.

1968 Martin Luther King, Jr., is assassinated in Memphis, Tennessee. Robert Kennedy is assassinated in Los Angeles while running for president.

1968 As the Vietnam conflict intensifies during the Tet Offensive, and opposition to the war grows, President Johnson decides not to run for reelection; Richard Nixon wins the election for the Republicans, but continues the US policy in Vietnam.

1969 Woodstock rock festival: more than 400,000 people attend a rock festival in upstate New York, one of the seminal events of the 1960s.



Nixon in China

In 1972 President Nixon attempted to normalize relations with communist China by making a historic visit. He did not know until he landed whether he would be allowed to meet Mao.

1969 Man on the moon: Neil Armstrong becomes the first man to walk on the moon when he steps off Apollo 11 on July 20, 1969: "That's one small step for a man, one giant leap for mankind."

1970 Four students are shot dead by National Guardsmen at Kent State University in Ohio, while protesting against the war in Vietnam.

1971 The 26th Amendment to the Constitution lowers the voting age to 18 in all elections. A proposed amendment guaranteeing women's rights is passed by Congress in 1973 but falls three states short of ratification in 1982.



Give 'em Hell, Harry!

Harry S. Truman's 1948 victory was a great political upset; before the polls closed, many newspapers (like the one held aloft by a grinning Truman the following morning) prematurely announced a Republican victory.